S-Move Dealer — QR stock-sync & in-shop scanning

Pre-planning plan + canvassing pack

Prepared 2026-06-30. Concept is technically achievable (confirmed). This document captures the full design we've worked through, and a field pack for getting real business interest BEFORE building. Take Part 11 canvassing.

PART A — THE PLAN

1. What it is, in one breath

QR codes on a shop's stock that keep its **online listings and its physical shelf in perfect agreement**, so the same one-off item can never be sold twice — once online and once over the counter. The shop's phone is the scanner. We handle the *stock truth*; we never handle the money at the point of sale.

2. The problem it solves

S-Move Dealer sells **unique, one-off items** (one chair, one antique, one ex-display piece). The moment a shop lists that item online, it's exposed to a real risk: a customer walks in and buys it off the shelf at the same moment someone buys it online → double sale, refund, embarrassed shopkeeper, damaged trust. For unique items this isn't a shrug (you can't just "reduce the count") — it's a genuine problem. This system makes the two worlds share one truth.

3. Principles locked in

1. **Stock truth, not a till.** At the point of sale our job is: know the item's state, and mark it sold. We do **not** take the money — the shop keeps using their own till / card reader. (No payment handling = no regulatory weight, no liability for the exchange.)
2. **One canonical availability state per item.** Online and in-shop read and write the *same* status field. There is never a separate "online stock" and "shop stock" — that would recreate the double-sell problem inside our own database.
3. **One QR = one physical item.** Each sticker is one specific thing. Scanned once, gone. This gives the strongest possible anti-double-sell guarantee and fits the unique-item model.
4. **Reserve on scan, instantly.** The instant an item is claimed (sell-scan or add-to-basket), its status flips — no lag, no waiting "for the database to catch up" (writes are milliseconds). Reserving instantly closes the race window to near zero; any delay would *open* a double-sell gap.
5. **Connectivity required (MVP).** A scan checks live availability against the server, so the phone needs signal. True offline mode is a much harder, later problem and is parked.
6. **The phone is the scanner.** No special hardware required, ever, for the core feature.

4. Item states

```
            +---------------------------+
            |        AVAILABLE          |
            +---------------------------+
               |                    |
    add to basket /          staff/customer
    online hold              sell-scan (in shop)
               v                    v
    +-------------------+   +-------------------+
    | ON HOLD (online) |   | RESERVED (shop)  |
    |  15-min timer    |   |  30–60 min timer |
    +-------------------+   +-------------------+
               |                    |
     payment captured      payment taken at till
               |                    |
               v                    v
            +---------------------------+
            |          SOLD             |
            +---------------------------+

(separate) MISSING  <- "can't locate / unable to fulfil"
           never auto-relisted
```

A hold/reservation that times out (or is released) returns the item to AVAILABLE.

5. The QR code itself

- A printed sticker (any printer) generated by our **QR generator** when the item is listed.
- Encodes the item's unique ID / URL.
- **Persists on the item forever** — including after it's sold and taken home (see repeat-business benefit).
- A scan of an *already-sold* item must still resolve to **the shop's profile**, never a dead "sold" page — months later that scan is a returning customer.

6. Two kinds of scan (keep these separate)

	Info-scan (read-only)	Sell/reserve-scan (claims the item)
Who	Anyone — customer's own phone camera	In-shop customer ("add to basket") or shop staff (selling)
Effect	Nothing — just shows information	Instantly changes availability (reserve / sold)
Shows	Item details, live availability, hold state + countdown, the shop's wider catalogue	—

7. Customer self-scan (info) — and why it's valuable

A customer in the shop scans an item with their phone camera and sees: - Full item details and price. - Live availability — and if it's on hold, a **countdown timer** until it frees up. - An **"add to basket"** option (reserves it for them, same as online). - The shop's **wider catalogue** — including stock **in the back, not yet on the shelf**.

Two standout benefits: - **Back-of-shop stock becomes browsable in-store.** Items being recorded/stored that haven't reached the shop floor are still discoverable by someone standing in the shop. Strong reason for shops to QR *everything*. - **Repeat business via the sticker.** A customer takes an item home, later wants to find the shop again — scans the QR still stuck on the bottom → lands on the shop's profile. Near-zero-cost marketing that drives return custom.

(Note: push notifications "it sold / it's available again" only reach customers who've installed the app and allowed notifications. The **in-page live countdown works for everyone**; treat push as a bonus for engaged users.)

8. The two purchase flows

Online

add to basket → **15-min hold** → checkout → **card authorised** → shop confirms it has the item → **payment captured** → SOLD → listing withdrawn everywhere instantly.

In shop

customer picks up / self-scans (optional **add-to-basket reserve, 30–60 min**) → at the till, staff **sell-scan** → item **reserved instantly** (blocks online from that millisecond) → staff take payment by their own means → confirm → **SOLD** → online listing withdrawn.

9. Conflict & priority rules (the tie-breakers)

1. **A hold is a courtesy, not a sale.**
2. **A completed payment is king** — nothing overrides it, online or in-store.
3. **The physically-present customer (item in hand) has priority over an online hold.** The shop's real, immediate sale beats an online browser who's still deciding.
4. **Online checkout re-checks availability at the moment of payment** — it never just trusts the hold it grabbed earlier. If the shop claimed it first, the online buyer gets an honest "sorry, just sold in-store" *before* being charged.
5. **Reserve-on-scan is instant**, so the race window is effectively closed.

10. Reservation management & release (in order of reliability)

1. **Shopkeeper manual release (PRIMARY).** Staff see a list of reserved items in their seller dashboard and can free any with one tap. They're physically present — they see the customer put it down or leave. A human on the floor beats any timer.
2. **Customer self-release.** A "remove from basket" button so a customer frees an item the moment they put it back on the shelf — naturally, item by item.
3. **Timeout (backstop).** Online holds 15 min; physical reservations longer (30–60 min, since in-shop browsing takes longer). The timer is the last line of defence, not the workhorse.
4. **Abuse guard.** A per-session reservation limit so one device can't lock up twenty items at once.
5. **Light session.** An in-shop camera scan spins up an anonymous session/basket on that phone so the basket, countdown and self-release all belong to someone — no full account needed. Staff can release reserved items without needing to know who reserved them.

> Reality check: for unique items in a local shop, the online-grabs-it-while-I-browse event is genuinely *rare* — low online traffic per one-off item. So this is a sensible safety net, not a machine to over-engineer. (We deliberately dropped a "scan a poster on the way out to clear your basket" idea — it relies on customers doing something they won't, and when they forget, the timeout handles it anyway. The self-release button does the same job better.)

11. Missing item / theft handling & liability

- **You are not accountable for a shop's missing stock or its refunds.** The contract of sale is buyer ↔ business; the business is the merchant of record; the money goes to the business's own Stripe; we never touch goods or money. A missing item is the shop's **inventory shrinkage** (an ordinary retail cost) and the refund is the shop's obligation as seller — the standard eBay/Etsy platform position. (Not legal advice — get the T&Cs drafted/reviewed. Three things keep this protection solid: clear "platform, not seller" terms; never behaving like the seller; terms stating the shop is responsible for keeping its own stock data accurate.)
- **The design move that mostly dissolves it: authorise-then-capture.** Online "buy" *authorises* the card but doesn't charge it until the shop confirms it has the item in hand. If the item can't be found, the authorisation simply expires — **the customer is never charged, no refund needed.** Perfect fit for physical one-off items. (Trade-off: adds a shop confirmation step, auth holds expire ~7 days. Simpler alternative = charge immediately, and the shop refunds via their own Stripe through a one-tap "unable to fulfil" action.)
- **The QR system reduces shrinkage** — a tracked inventory beats a manual till — so it's part of the solution, not just exposed to the problem.
- **Protect platform reputation anyway:** track each shop's **fulfilment-failure rate**; consistently flaky shops get flagged, coached or suspended.

12. Hardware

The phone is the scanner — staff and customers open the web app / PWA and point the camera. Optional Bluetooth/USB 2D scanners (~£30–150) exist for a fixed counter station *later*, but are never required. Making hardware mandatory would kill adoption in exactly the manual-till shops we're targeting.

13. What exists vs net-new (build reality)

- Already building: stock tracking in the S-Move admin (dogfood on our own stock first — perfect proving ground), and the QR generator.
- Already exists online: the 15-minute reservation mechanism.
- Net-new: the in-shop scan web app/PWA, the per-item single-source-of-truth status wiring, the seller-facing reservation dashboard, the customer self-scan info view, and (if chosen) the auth-then-capture checkout step.
- **Prove it on our own stock until it's bulletproof before any business touches it** — when it fails it fails *at the till with a customer waiting*, so the reliability bar is high.

14. Revenue model

A **paid feature on a monthly subscription** (consistent with the checkout-feature decision — flat fee by Direct Debit, no commission, we stay out of the money). Open question: bundle QR-stock-sync with the online-checkout feature as one "sell online + sync your shop" tier, or sell it as its own thing. The stock-sync may actually be the *stronger* hook — it delivers value even to shops that barely sell online (free stock control + never double-sell). Price to be validated by canvassing.

15. Open questions to settle before build

1. Auth-then-capture vs charge-immediately for the online checkout side?
2. Physical reservation length — 30 or 60 minutes?
3. Bundle with online checkout, or separate tier? One price or two?
4. What monthly price do shops find fair? (Canvassing answers this.)
5. Capacity: when do you build it, given it follows the checkout feature in sequence?

PART B — CANVASSING PACK

Use this in front of shopkeepers to test interest BEFORE building

The 30-second pitch (plain language)

> "We give your shop a page on the S-Move app where local people can find and buy your stock. The clever part: we put a little QR sticker on each item. Scan it with any phone and it keeps your online listings and your actual shelf in sync — so you can never accidentally sell the same one-off item twice, once online and once in the shop. It's also free stock control: scan an item to record a sale, see what's still available, even show customers stock that's still out the back. Your phone is the scanner — no special kit, and we never touch your money, you keep taking payment however you do now."

Lead with these benefits (in their language)

- **"Never double-sell."** Sell the same unique item online and in-store at once? Can't happen — the moment it sells one way, it's gone the other.
- **"Free stock control."** Especially for shops on a manual till with no barcodes — scan to record what's sold and what's left, no spreadsheet.
- **"Sell stuff that's still in the back."** Items not even on the shelf yet become browsable by customers standing in your shop.
- **"Customers find you again."** The QR stays on the item — months later they scan it and land back on your shop.
- **"Less stuff goes walkabout."** A tracked inventory beats a manual till for spotting what's gone missing.
- **"Use your own phone."** No tills to buy, no contracts. We never handle your money.

Questions to ask (this is the actual validation)

Stock & current pain: 1. "How do you track your stock today — till, notebook, spreadsheet, memory?" 2. "Do you have barcodes on your items, or not really?" 3. "Have you ever sold something and then couldn't find it — or sold the same thing twice by mistake?" 4. "Roughly how often do things go missing or get miscounted?"

Fit & willingness: 5. "Would you be willing to put a QR sticker on each item as it comes in?" 6. "Would you (or your staff) be happy scanning items on a phone to record a sale?" 7. "Would having your back-stock visible to customers in the shop be useful to you?"

Price (the big one): 8. "If this saved you the double-selling risk and gave you stock control, what would feel fair to pay per month? Would £X feel reasonable?" *(test a couple of price points — e.g. £15, £25, £40)* 9. "Would you want this on its own, or bundled with letting customers buy from your page online?"

Signals to listen for

🟢 Green (build it): "I've definitely sold something twice / lost track" · "I'd pay for that" · "I hate my current system" · asks when it's available. 🔴 Red (rethink): "I already use Square/Shopify and it's fine" · "I'd never put stickers on everything" · "my stock's all in my head and that works" · won't name any price.

What to write down for each shop

- Current stock method · had a double-sell/loss before? (y/n) · willing to sticker & scan? (y/n) · price they'd accept · bundle or standalone · overall interest (hot/warm/cold).

Related

Pairs with the direct-checkout pre-planning brief (`E:\S-Move\Marketplace App\App Marketing Material\Dealer Direct Checkout - Pre-Planning Brief.md`) and the revenue forecaster (`E:\S-Move\Marketplace App\App Marketing Material\Dealer Sponsored Pricing Forecaster.html`). Canvassing targets: the no-website / manual-till shops in `E:\Claude\Canvas Research\`.